large and small variable speed lathes. Unfortunately lathes were developed by engineers who did not understand the functions required for the hobbyist turner who was looking to make items but not necessarily for sale. Lathe makers today need to listen to turners.

Your safety in the workshop

Available now are fully protected powered respirators, for use in turning, carving and sanding applications. They are much lighter than the older versions and offer good vision. Combination face seal and hoods have improved protection for eyes and face against flying objects, they can also have earmuffs. With turners now using acrylic, plastics and dangerous woods, you must wear a mask or respirator. DO NOT MAKE ANY EXCEPTION, the dust will harm you. Sanding of pieces made on the lathe has developed using water, oil, superglue as a filler, improved types of sandpaper using coarse to fine grit paper, supported by using sharp tools, brings better understanding of quality sharpening.

Sanding methods

The latest sanding abrasives are much better in quality today. Turners can use abrasive cord grit in various grades, grits, gold sand mops, mesh green discs, sanding sticks in sets of three, sandflex abrasive blocks, Mac Mops, Flapwheel, Mesh paper, etc.

Australian-made product finishes

U-Beaut Polishes were developed by Neil Ellis, he has a woodturning and carving background but found there was not a suitable finish available for turners. So U-Beaut was created and Neil developed a finish that worked instantly on the wood on or off the lathe. The finishes are suitable for smaller items, such as pens, ornaments, small bowls, door knobs and bowls. The products have been very successful, with overseas distributors in USA, Canada, South Africa, New Zealand, the Netherlands, and distribution all over Europe, Taiwan, China and Japan. This is an example of an Australian product now accepted worldwide. Other areas that have developed are variety of turning tools with better quality, from traditional gouges, skews, scrapers, and the quality of component parts for day to day turners.

Conclusion

In this article I have tried to show how turning has developed. There are many technical aspects that have improved – types of lathes, variable speeds, rotary sanders, hollowing with and without laser, vacuum plate development, etc. – but safety equipment is also better in terms of versatility and accuracy compared to 20 years ago.

If you do not know how to turn, but want to learn, make use of all the magazines, videos, DVDs, books, attend clubs, symposiums, some private teachers, use the internet – every bit of exposure will assist. If you do know how to turn, there are lots of ways to share your knowledge. My philosophy is the more you give and research, the more you will receive. ●

Vic Wood setting up to demonstrate a 'container series' lidded box in blackwood with pine surrounding

Oak bowl – turned wet and edge beaded, then burnt with a propane torch. The dark colour inside the bowl was from water staining. 330 x 180mm

'Burnt Edge Bowl' in red gum. Turned one year after the tree had been cut, the wood was still a little damp on the inside. Red gum continues to dry as you sand. Felling shakes appear in this piece. 355 x 63mm

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